ALPHA FEMALE

FOR OLYMPIC MEDALLIST MIRABAI CHANU, setbacks have often been the springboards for bigger achievements. Seeking her maiden Asian Games medal earlier this year, she injured her right thigh at Hangzhou and managed just two lifts out of six attempts to finish fourth in the women's 49 kg category. But the diminutive weightlifter from Manipur has not lost sight of her next goal—an Olympic gold medal. She won the silver at the 2020 Tokyo Olympics (held in 2021), becoming the second Indian weightlifter to win an Olympic medal after Karnam Malleswari, who won a bronze in 2000.

In her quest to better the Tokyo Olympics performance, Chanu, still recovering from her injury, marked her attendance at the IWF Grand Prix II in Doha in December, as participating in this event is mandatory to qualify for the 2024 Paris Olympics. She did the same in the 2023 World Championships in Riyadh held in September. Her goal is now to achieve fitness for the Asian championships, another Olympic qualifying event, which will be held in Tashkent in February next year.

Injuries have never deterred Chanu, the two-time Commonwealth Games gold medallist, who was awarded the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna award in 2018. In 2022, she was battling a wrist issue but still participated in the World Weightlifting Championships in Bogota, Colombia, and earned a silver medal. In 2017, she had won the gold. The glory had come at a cost—she had to skip her sister's wedding.

Comebacks have been a constant in Chanu's career. In the Rio Olympics in 2016, she crashed out after failing to lift the weight in any of her three attempts in the clean-and-jerk section. Dejected, she cut herself off from the world, focusing only on her game. Five years later, at the Asian championship in Tashkent, she went on to create a world record, lifting an incredible 119 kg.

Born in Nongpok Kakching village, 45 km south of Manipur's capital Imphal, Chanu initially wanted to be an archer. Then, in Class 8, she read a chapter on Kunjarani Devi, another iconic weightlifter from Manipur, and Chanu, the youngest of six siblings, decided to follow in her footsteps. She got instant support from her mother, who by now had noticed that her daughter could lift things in the household that her sons could not. Till date, she has not let her mother down. ■

-Kaushik Deka



GETTY IMAGES

Saikhom Mirabai Chanu, *29*
Weightlifter

ACCOMPLISHMENT

An Olympic silver medallist and former world champion, she picked up her second Commonwealth Games gold in 2022

↘ STRESS BUSTER
Loves cooking, dancing and doing paper craft

↘ CHEAT MEALS
Pizza, ice cream

↘ LUCKY CHARM
When going for a competition, she prefers to wear red